Q3FY26 PREVIEW

SECTOR UPDATE

nuvama institutional equities

Growth sustains despite seasonal lull

We expect Q3FY26E EBITDA of our healthcare coverage to expand ~22% YoY propelled by ~22% growth in hospitals and diagnostics. Highlights: i) Diagnostics likely to clock 13% organic growth alongside margin expansion (~107bp YoY). ii) Hospitals face a seasonally soft quarter, but APHS/Fortis shall still post healthy hospital revenue growth of 14%/19% YoY driven by bed additions and ARPOBs. iii) Apollo Pharmacy to sustain ~17% YoY growth while Medplus shall post ~15% growth YoY driven by increased traction in non-pharma.

We reckon APHS, Fortis, Metropolis, Vijaya and Medplus shall post good numbers, whereas Max and Laxmi Dental would report softness. Jupiter Life and Dr Lal remain on a firm growth path.

Hospitals: Seasonally soft; APHS and Fortis to report strong growth

While Q3 is a seasonally soft quarter, we expect hospitals under our coverage to post revenue/EBITDA growth of 15%/22% YoY, driven by ARPOBs and new bed additions. **APHS:** Hospital revenue growth to improve to 14% with margins steady at ~24% despite addition of Pune hospital. Occupancy muted at 65% (versus 68% YoY) with ARPOB up 13% YoY. **Fortis:** Healthy hospital growth of ~19% YoY; margin healthy at 23% (+260bp YoY) aided by bed additions and the Shrimann acquisition. Occupancy estimated at ~67% and ARPOB growth at 5% YoY. Agilus is likely to grow 9% YoY with margins at ~24% versus 15% in Q3FY25. **Max:** We expect subdued growth of 10% due to high dengue base last year, GST on oncology drugs, insurance impact and all hospitals coming into the base with EBTIDA margins at ~26.7% (-58bp YoY). **Jupiter:** Revenue growth steady at 15% YoY with stable margin of 23.1%. Occupancy to be ~63% (versus 65.7% in Q3FY25) due to addition of beds in Indore.

Diagnostics: Growth bounces back after soft Q2

We reckon diagnostics' revenue/PAT shall grow 17%/25% YoY led by ~13% organic growth and rest via acquisitions. Q3 is likely to outpace earlier expectations owing to a pickup in specialty and allergy business, low base and festival timing. Metropolis leads growth (+26% YoY reported; +15% YoY organic), followed by Vijaya (~17% YoY) and Dr Lal (~12% YoY)—all shall report margin expansion YoY.

Medplus growth to improve; sector triggers ahead for growth

Like diagnostics, pharmacy business shall also deliver strong growth. We expect Medplus to post 15%/37% YoY revenue/PAT growth, driven by non-pharma. Apollo HealthCo shall sustain ~17% growth with 24/7 GMV up ~5% QoQ and flat costs. Laxmi Dental is likely to report a soft quarter due to US tariffs and weak season. Key monitorables: i) Hospitals' commentary on bed expansion and insurance resolution. ii) Diagnostics: eye on acquisitions, price hikes and DLPL's radiology foray. iii) Medplus: SSSG improvement. iv) Laxmi Dental: growth pickup and US tariffs impact.

Q3: Outperformers: APHS, Fortis, Metropolis, Vijaya Diagnostics, Medplus. **Underperformers:** Max Healthcare, Laxmi Dental.

Top Picks: APHS, Max Healthcare, Vijaya Diagnostics, Metropolis.

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Exhibit 1: Nuvama Healthcare coverage universe—Q3FY26 estimates

	Net Sales			Adjusted EBITDA			EBITDA Margin (%)			Adjusted PAT		
	Q3FY26	Y-o-Y (%)	Q-o-Q (%)	Q3FY26	Y-o-Y (%)	Q-o-Q (%)	Q3FY26	Y-o-Y (%)	Q-o-Q (%)	Q3FY26	Y-o-Y (%)	Q-o-Q (%)
Apollo Hospitals	63,841	15.5	1.3	9,480	24.5	0.7	14.9	107bps	-8bps	4,809	29.2	0.8
Max Healthcare	25,305	10.9	(1.9)	6,752	8.6	(2.7)	26.7	-58bps	-22bps	3,990	6.3	(1.5)
Fortis Healthcare	22,592	17.2	(3.1)	5,209	38.9	(6.4)	23.1	360bps	-80bps	2,706	19.5	(11.0)
Jupiter Lifeline	3,697	14.8	(6.1)	854	11.8	0.1	23.1	-62bps	30bps	492	(6.1)	(2.5)
Yatharth Hospitals	3,006	37.2	7.6	697	27.0	8.1	23.2	-186bps	11bps	387	26.8	(6.3)
Hospitals	**1,18,441**	**15.2**	**(0.4)**	**22,993**	**21.7**	**(1.8)**	**19.4**	**102bps**	**-28bps**	**12,384**	**17.2**	**(3.1)**
Dr Lal Pathlabs	6,678	11.9	(8.6)	1,775	15.2	(20.8)	26.6	77bps	-410bps	1,157	19.7	(23.1)
Metropolis	4,071	26.1	(5.2)	993	37.9	(8.2)	24.4	209bps	-82bps	476	51.7	(9.7)
Vijaya Diagnostics	1,971	16.7	(2.2)	794	18.3	(2.9)	40.3	57bps	-30bps	410	16.6	(5.3)
Diagnostics	**12,720**	**16.9**	**(6.6)**	**3,562**	**21.5**	**(14.0)**	**28.0**	**107bps**	**-242bps**	**2,043**	**25.2**	**(17.1)**
MedPlus	17,957	15.0	6.9	904	20.9	9.9	5.0	25bps	14bps	627	36.7	13.1
Laxmi Dental	685	11.0	(5.3)	92	(4.6)	(16.8)	13.4	-219bps	-185bps	81	68.7	(5.1)
Overall-Healthcare	**1,49,803**	**15.3**	**(0.1)**	**27,552**	**21.5**	**(3.3)**	**18.4**	**93bps**	**-60bps**	**15,136**	**19.1**	**(4.7)**

Source: Company, Nuvama Research

**Post rent i.e. Operating EBITDA*

Exhibit 2: Key healthcare earnings expectations along with comments

Stock		Q3FY26E	Q3FY25	*YoY growth*	Q2FY26	*QoQ growth*	Comments
Apollo Hospitals	Revenues	63,841	55,269	*15.5*	63,035	*1.3*	Overall revenue shall grow by ~16% YoY, largely driven by hospital revenue growth of 13-14%. Hospital revenue growth is supported by 5% IP volume growth, with the rest driven by ARPP. Occupancy is likely to remain muted at 65% (-250bp YoY) due to the addition of new beds, while ARPOBs are expected to grow by ~13% YoY to INR68,000. Hospital EBITDA margins are expected to remain at ~24.4% (~+37bps YoY) with EBITDA of INR7.7bn (+15% YoY). The overall pharmacy business is projected to grow by ~17% driven by ~17% offline business growth. 24/7 GMV is expected to improve to INR7.6bn i.e. (+6% QoQ). We expect pharmacy margins to be at ~4.7% (~+226bp YoY/~+53bp QoQ) with EBITDA of INR1.3bn. We expect overall EBITDA of INR9.48bn, +24% YoY, with margins improving by ~107bp YoY to
	EBITDA	9,480	7,615	*24.5*	9,411	*0.7*	
	PAT	4,809	3,723	*29.2*	4,772	*0.8*	
Dr. Lal Pathlabs	Revenues	6,678	5,967	*11.9*	7,306	*(8.6)*	Revenue/PAT is estimated to grow by ~12%/20% YoY, primarily driven by 11% sample volumes and mix change thus driving operating leverage. Patient growth is likely to be ~5%. We expect EBITDA to grow by ~15% YoY, with EBITDA margin at ~26.6%, +75bp YoY but -410bp QoQ due to soft season. PAT growth is estimated to be 20% YoY.
	EBITDA	1,775	1,540	*15.2*	2,241	*(20.8)*	
	PAT	1,157	967	*19.7*	1,506	*(23.1)*	
Fortis Healthcare	Revenues	22,592	19,283	*17.2*	23,314	*(3.1)*	We estimate overall revenue to grow by ~17% YoY, driven by ~19% growth in hospitals and ~8% growth in diagnostics. Hospital growth is expected to be supported by bed additions, with occupancy likely at 67% versus 71% in Q2FY26 and 67% in Q3FY25 due to bed additions. Hospital EBITDA margins are expected to be ~22.6% (~+250 bps YoY/-30bp QoQ). Agilus Diagnostics is likely to report margins of ~24% (versus 15% in Q3FY25), driven by operating leverage and an improved test mix.
	EBITDA	5,209	3,751	*38.9*	5,563	*(6.4)*	
	PAT	2,706	2,265	*19.5*	3,041	*(11.0)*	
Jupiter Lifeline	Revenues	3,697	3,220	*14.8*	3,936	*(6.1)*	We expect Jupiter's revenue to grow by ~15% YoY driven by 8% ARPOB growth and ~6% volume growth. Overall occupancy is expected to be at 63% versus 65.7% in Q3FY25, impacted by the addition of beds in Indore. EBITDA margin is likely to decline to 23.1%, down ~62 bps YoY, slightly impacted by higher employee costs and opex.
	EBITDA	854	764	*11.8*	853	*0.1*	
	PAT	492	524	*(6.1)*	505	*(2.5)*	
Laxmi Dental	Revenues	685	617	*11.0*	723	*(5.3)*	Revenue is expected to grow by ~11% YoY/-5% QoQ to INR685mn impacted by season and US tariff impact. EBITDA margin is expected to come in at 13.5%, ~-220bp YoY impacted by US tariffs. PAT expected at INR81mn vs INR48mn in Q3FY25.
	EBITDA	92	96	*-4.6*	110	*(16.8)*	
	PAT	81	48	*68.7*	85	*(5.1)*	
Max Healthcare	Revenues	25,305	22,810	*10.9*	25,800	*(1.9)*	We expect Max Healthcare's revenue growth to remain muted at ~11% YoY, impacted by seasonality, insurance-related issues, GST on pharmacy drugs, and a high base effect, while EBITDA margins are likely to remain stable QoQ at 26.7% but -60bp YoY. We expect large part of the growth to be volume driven as ARPOB is projected to grow 2% YoY/flat QoQ to INR77,500. Overall occupancy is expected to remain flat YoY at ~75% but -200bp QoQ due to seasonality. PAT is expected to be INR 3,979 mn (+6% YoY) impacted by epxansions.
	EBITDA	6,752	6,220	*8.6*	6,940	*(2.7)*	
	PAT	3,979	3,754	*6.0*	4,050	*(1.7)*	

Source: Company, Nuvama Research

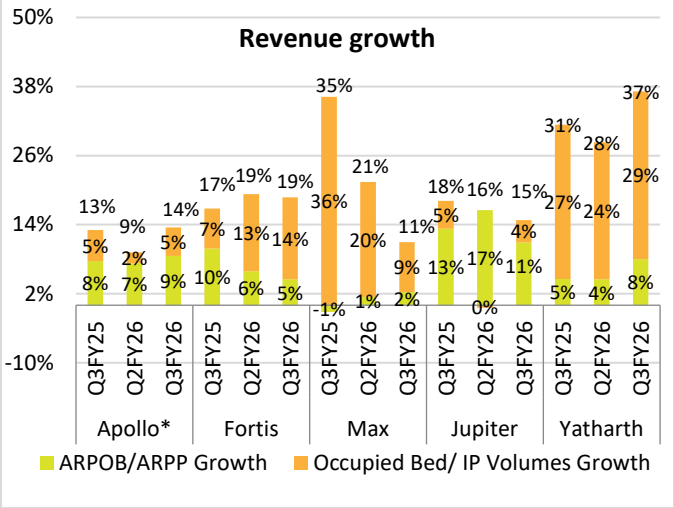
Key healthcare earnings expectations along with comments (Contd.)

Stock		Q3FY26E	Q3FY25	*YoY growth*	Q2FY26	*QoQ growth*	Comments
MedPlus Health	Revenues	17,957	15,614	*15.0*	16,793	*6.9*	We estimate revenue growth to be robust at ~15% YoY (versus ~7% in Q2FY26), led by pickup in non-pharma segment and continued growth in other segments. ~180 net store additions are expected in Q3FY26E (~400 additions in 9MFY26E). Gross margins are likely to remain healthy at ~26.1% (~+107 bp YoY/flat QoQ), driven by a higher private label mix (~23% versus 19.6% in Q3FY25 and 21.7% in Q2FY26). Improved gross profit should support operating EBITDA of ~INR 904 mn (~+21% YoY), with margins at ~5% (+25 bp YoY). Diagnostic revenue is expected at ~INR 334 mn (+18% YoY), with EBITDA margins of ~15%. PAT is projected to grow ~37% YoY to ~INR 627 mn.
	Operating EB	904	748	*20.9*	823	*9.9*	
	PAT	627	459	*36.7*	555	*13.1*	
Metropolis	Revenues	4,071	3,228	*26.1*	4,292	*(5.2)*	Overall revenue is estimated to grow by ~26% YoY, driven by ~15% growth in the base business, with balance growth coming from inorganic acquisitions including Core Diagnostics. Organic growth is expected to be supported by ~8% YoY patient volume growth (~16% YoY on a consol basis) driven by increased traction in specialty and preventive tests. Organic margins are likely to improve marginally to ~25%+ (+300bps YoY), while reported margins are expected to be around ~24.4% (~+210bp YoY). We expect Core Diagnostics to report positive single-digit margins at ~6%. PAT is expected to be at INR476mn (+52% YoY).
	EBITDA	993	720	*37.9*	1,082	*(8.2)*	
	PAT	476	314	*51.7*	527	*(9.7)*	
Vijaya Diagnostics	Revenues	1,971	1,690	*16.7*	2,016	*(2.2)*	Overall sales are expected to grow by ~17% YoY, largely driven by volumes. As growth in the previous quarter was affected by seasonality and festivities, a rebound is expected in the coming quarters, supported by the planned addition of new hubs in the near term and improving performance of newly opened centres. We expect EBITDA to rise 18% YoY, with margins at 40.3% (+57bp YoY).
	EBITDA	794	671	*18.3*	818	*(2.9)*	
	PAT	410	352	*16.6*	433	*(5.3)*	
Yatharth Hospitals	Revenues	3,006	2,192	*37.2*	2,794	*7.6*	Yatharth's revenue is expected to grow by ~37% YoY and 8% QoQ to INR3bn. ARPOB is projected to increase by ~8% YoY to INR33,100, while overall occupancy is expected to be at 56% (vs 66% in Q2FY26 and 60% in Q3FY25) due to the addition of new beds. EBITDA margins are likely to remain steady QoQ at ~23.2%, but declining by ~180 bps YoY, mainly due to higher operating expenses
	EBITDA	697	549	*27.0*	645	*8.1*	
	PAT	387	305	*26.8*	412	*(6.3)*	

Source: Company, Nuvama Research

Hospitals — Seasonally soft quarter

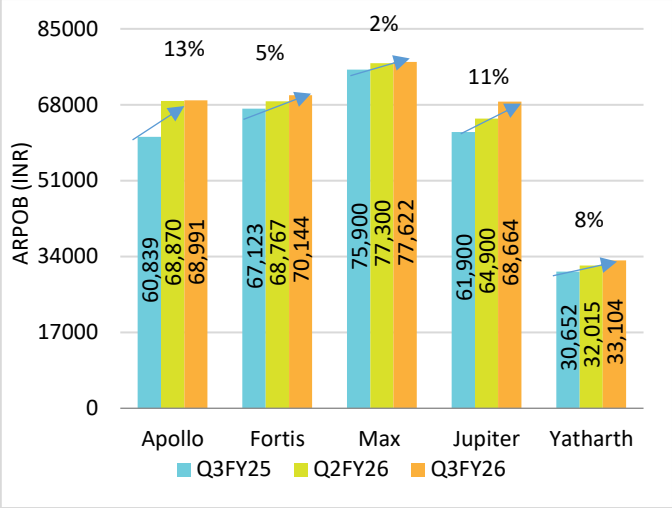
Exhibit 3: Revenue growth steady, barring Max



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

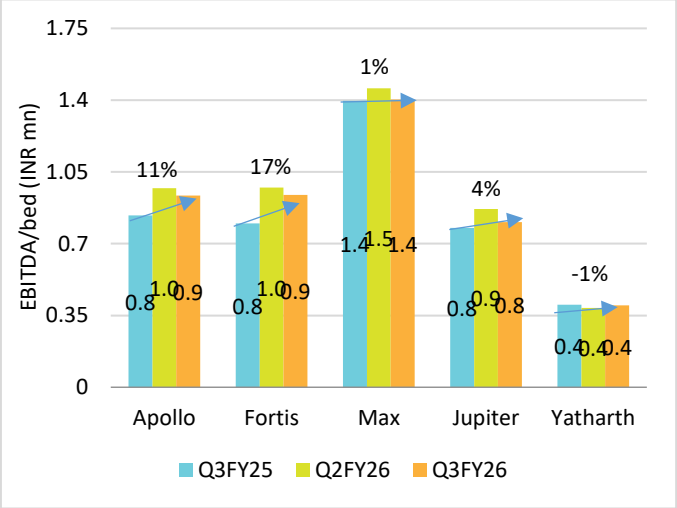
**ARPP growth is considered for Apollo*

Exhibit 4: Apollo outpaces peers on ARPOB growth



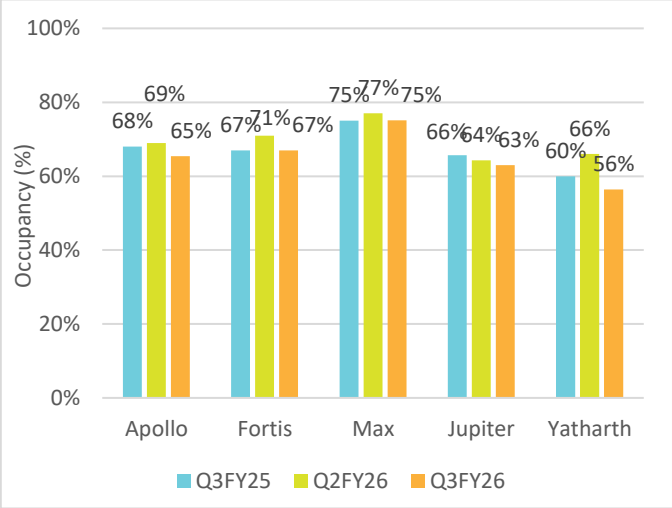
Source: Company, Nuvama Research

Exhibit 5: Fortis and Apollo post healthy EBITDA per bed YoY



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

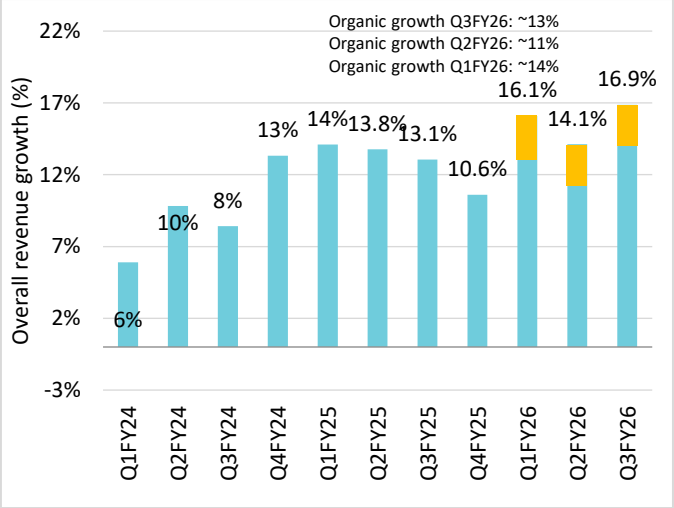
Exhibit 6: Bed additions affect occupancy



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

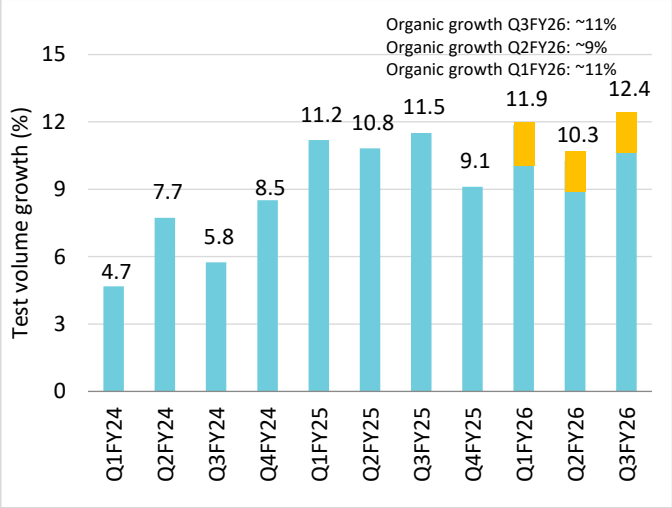
Diagnostics—Strong growth in the offing

Exhibit 7: Revenue growth propelled by seasonality, low base



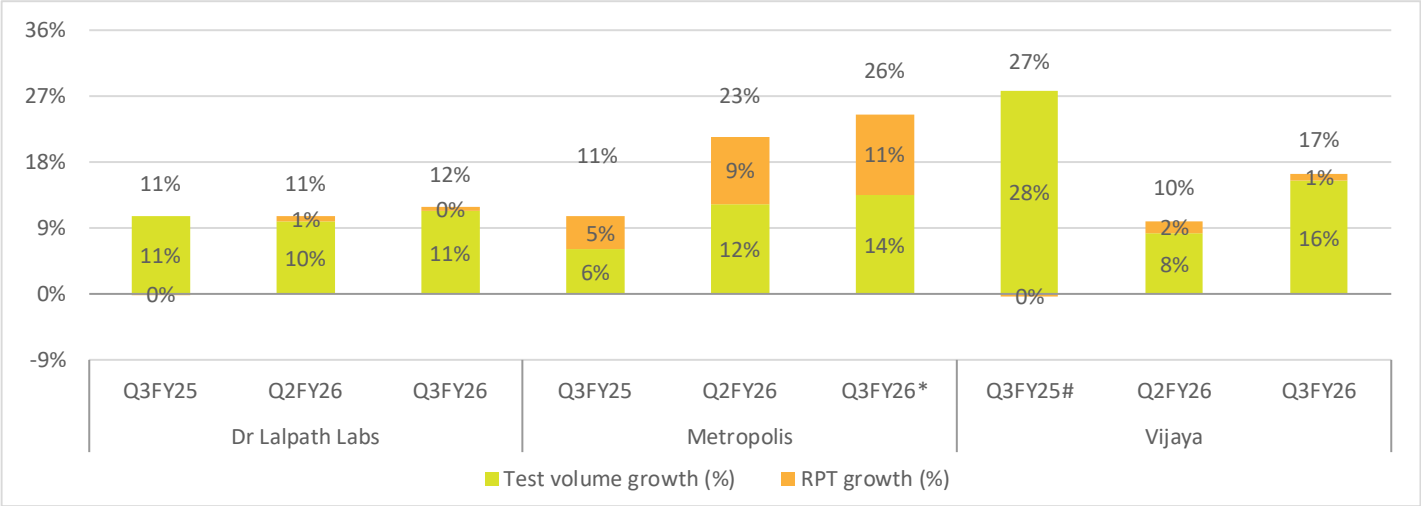
Source: Company, Nuvama Research

Exhibit 8: Volumes poised for recovery after weak Q2FY26



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

Exhibit 9: Diagnostics growth by company: Metropolis to outperform; Vijaya growth recovers; Dr Lal remains steady



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

**Metropolis's base business growth: 12%/15% YoY for Q2FY26/Q3FY26E*

#Vijaya Diagnostics's base business growth: 20% YoY for Q3FY25

All price charts cannot be included given the large of number of companies in our coverage. Specific charts may be available upon request

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